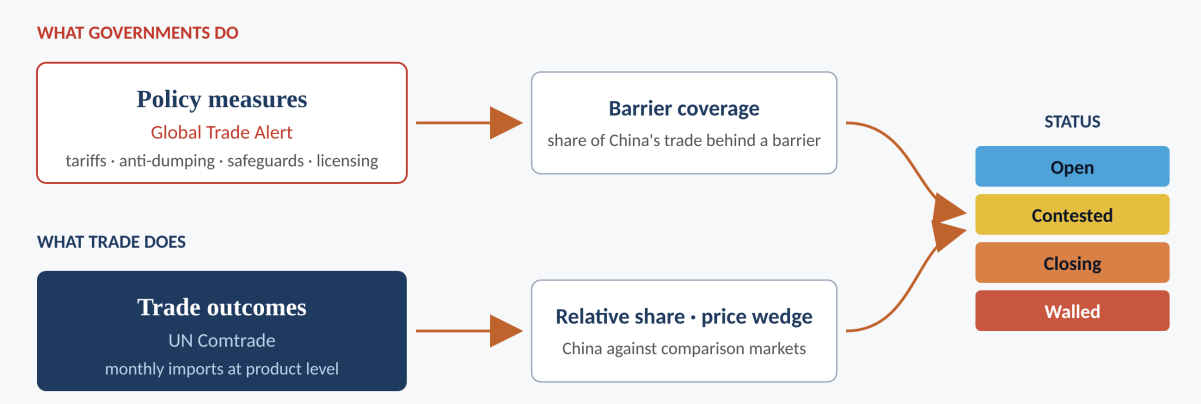
Is the Global South Closing to Chinese Exports?

An Explainer

How Market Access Sentry tracks the trade barriers going up against China’s exports across twelve Global South markets, and what the data show so far.



30%
Share of China’s 2023 exports to these markets now behind a barrier erected since 2022

9 of 60
Market–sector pairs that read walled or closing

2
Pairs that read walled: India and Mexico, both in steel

96%→57%
China’s share of Thailand’s solar imports, with no new barrier in place

Simon Lacey

November 2026 edition · Policy measures to October 2026 · Trade data to May 2026

Executive Summary

China's export surge has shifted from the wealthier and more mature markets of the United States and Europe to countries in the so-called "Global South". As Washington and Brussels have raised their own barriers, more Chinese steel, aluminum, chemicals, solar products and electric vehicles have been heading to India, Latin America, Southeast Asia, Africa and the Middle East. Governments in those markets have begun to respond, and hardly a week now passes without a new anti-dumping case or tariff increase aimed at Chinese goods.

Simply counting these measures, however, tells us relatively little about whether they are having any effect. A tariff increase may well apply to product lines in which China supplies very little to begin with, while Chinese exporters faced with an anti-dumping duty may choose to absorb it by lowering their prices, or to route their goods through a third country instead. By the same token, China can lose market share in a market where no barrier has been put in place at all, for the simple reason that local producers, or suppliers from elsewhere, have become more competitive.

Market Access Sentry was designed with this distinction in mind, namely to separate the barriers that are genuinely changing how Chinese goods enter a market from those that have so far made little discernible difference. For each of twelve markets and five sectors, it sets the barriers put in place since 2022 against what has happened to China's market share and prices in the same products. A market counts as closing only when Chinese goods lose ground or are forced to price up, not when measures accumulate on paper. This explainer sets out how the Sentry works, how to read it, and what the first data show.

This explainer is not investment, legal, or compliance advice. It is intended for professionals operating at the intersection of trade policy, geopolitics, and supply chain strategy. Figures are stated as of the November 2026 data refresh: policy measures to October 31, 2026, and trade data to May 2026 for most markets.

In Short

Barriers against Chinese goods are now widespread across the Global South, but walls that actually hold are still rare. Of the sixty market–sector pairs the Sentry tracks, only two read walled and seven read closing. In most of the rest, China's share has held steady or grown, including in several markets that have put substantial barriers in place.

- **Barriers are spreading, but walls are rare.** Some 30 percent of China's 2023 exports to the twelve markets, worth around $132 billion that year, now sit behind a barrier erected since 2022. Yet only India and Mexico, both in steel, combine heavy coverage with a clear and absolute loss of Chinese market share.
- **Some walls exist mostly on paper.** Barriers cover 94 percent of China's aluminum exports to Mexico and all of its EV and battery exports to Brazil. China's share has risen in both, from 25 to 29 percent in Mexican aluminum and from 54 to 81 percent in Brazilian EVs and batteries.
- **Some of China's biggest losses have nothing to do with barriers.** China's share of Thailand's solar imports fell from 96 to 57 percent, and its share of South Africa's EV and battery imports from 91 to 79 percent, with no new barrier in place in either. Chinese solar exports to Vietnam fell from $1.6 billion to $0.6 billion, the downstream effect of US duties on Southeast Asian solar rather than of any Vietnamese measure.
- **India is where barriers bite hardest.** Brazil and Türkiye have the highest coverage, but India is the only market with a walled or closing reading in three sectors, and open investigations there cover a further 20 percent of China's trade, most of it in chemicals.
- **Mexico's EV market is the case to watch.** Tariffs of up to 50 percent on vehicles from countries without a trade agreement took effect on January 1, 2026. China's share of Mexico's EV and battery imports nonetheless doubled to 39 percent in the year to May 2026, a period that includes stockpiling ahead of the increase.

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Why the Global South, and Why Now

China ran a trade surplus of around $1.2 trillion in 2025, a record, as weak domestic demand and state-supported investment in manufacturing capacity pushed more output abroad. With the United States and the European Union raising barriers of their own, an increasing share of that output has gone to emerging and developing economies. The shift has been widely noted. *Foreign Policy* has described a coming clash between China and the Global South; KfW Development Research has set out the costs and benefits for developing economies; and the US Federal Reserve has compared today's "China Shock 2.0" with the first one of the early 2000s.

The question these accounts leave open is how the receiving markets respond, and whether their responses change anything. Cheap Chinese inputs lower costs for downstream industry and, in the case of solar panels and batteries, speed up the energy transition. They also put pressure on local producers, who have increasingly asked their governments for protection.

The Sentry's twelve markets were chosen because each is large enough for Chinese exports to matter and has the administrative capacity to respond: India, Brazil, Mexico, Indonesia, Thailand, Malaysia, South Africa, Türkiye, Argentina, Egypt, Nigeria and Vietnam. The five sectors are those in which Chinese overcapacity has been most discussed and most contested: steel, aluminum, chemicals, solar products, and EVs and batteries. Chemicals are included because the European Union is now moving against Chinese chemical imports, having opened an anti-dumping investigation into PVC from China in September 2026 among others, and any wall there is likely to push more product toward the markets tracked here.

How the Sentry Works

The Sentry draws on two sources. Policy measures come from Global Trade Alert, which records government interventions affecting trade, with dates, instruments and the product lines covered. Trade outcomes come from UN Comtrade, which publishes each country's monthly imports by product and by partner. Every reading in the tool combines the two at the level of six-digit product lines, of which the five sectors cover around 1,000.

Barrier coverage

Coverage measures how much of China's trade with a market now sits behind a border barrier. It is calculated as the share of China's 2023 exports to that market, by value, in product lines covered by at least one barrier that was put in place since January 2022 and remains in force. Fixing the weights at 2023 means coverage rises only when new barriers go up, not when trade shifts between lines.

Several choices shape what counts as a barrier:

- **Border measures only.** Tariffs, anti-dumping and countervailing duties, safeguards, quotas and import licensing count. Subsidies to local producers do not, although they can have a similar effect.
- **Measures from 2022 onward.** Tariffs and duties in place before 2022 are treated as part of the baseline. They shaped the 2023 starting point and are shown in the tool, but they do not count toward coverage.
- **Open investigations are shown separately.** An anti-dumping or safeguard investigation that has been opened but not concluded is counted as pending. It signals pressure but has not yet changed the terms of entry.
- **Measures that pull investment in are flagged, but not counted.** Local-content rules and tariff schedules tied to local assembly, such as Brazil's rising EV tariff ladder, are designed to bring Chinese production into a market rather than keep Chinese goods out. The tool marks them "Pull investment" and leaves them out of coverage.
- **Measures aimed at other products are set aside.** Some measures fall on a sector's product lines but target something else, such as rules on phone and wearables batteries or on low-value e-commerce parcels. These are excluded, as are a small number of records reviewed individually, with reasons recorded.

Relative share

A falling Chinese share of a market's imports does not by itself show that a barrier is working. China's share may be falling everywhere, or rising everywhere at a different pace. The Sentry therefore compares China's share in each market

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with its share in a fixed group of comparison importers in the same products, re-weighted to the market's own product mix. The comparison group comprises Mexico, Indonesia, Malaysia, Thailand, South Africa, Chile, Australia, Canada, Japan, the United Kingdom and Germany, with each tracked market excluded from its own comparison.

The result is expressed as an index, with 2023 set at 100. The index is not a market share, and should not be read as one. A reading below 100 means that China's position in that market has weakened since 2023 relative to how it has fared in comparison markets in the same products, while a reading above 100 means it has strengthened. A reading of 81 for Indian steel, for example, does not mean that China supplies 81 percent of India's steel imports. It means that China's position there is roughly a fifth weaker than in 2023 once its performance elsewhere is taken into account, for the simple reason that its share of India's steel imports fell from 16 to 14 percent over a period in which its share of comparison markets' imports edged up.

The price wedge

A barrier does not always show up as lost volume. Chinese exporters may hold on to their share by absorbing a duty or, alternatively, pass it on and land their goods at higher prices. The price wedge compares the change since 2023 in China's unit values into a market with the change in its unit values into comparison markets, product by product. A positive wedge means Chinese goods are landing at higher prices in that market than elsewhere. Because unit values also move with the mix of products within a line, product lines whose price moves more than threefold are discarded, and a wedge beyond 40 percent in either direction is not used.

Vietnam

Vietnam reports its monthly trade to UN Comtrade with a long delay. The Sentry therefore reads Vietnam from China's own annual export data, comparing the growth of China's exports to Vietnam with the growth of its exports worldwide. The resulting index is again set at 100 in 2023 and is read in the same way, as a measure of how China is faring in Vietnam relative to elsewhere rather than as a market share, but it is calculated on annual rather than rolling monthly data.

Reading the Statuses

Each market–sector pair is assigned one of four statuses by published rules, applied mechanically to the latest data. No status is set by hand. A barrier counts as "going up" when coverage has risen by at least 10 percentage points over the past twelve months, or stands at 50 percent or more.

Status	Rule	Example
Walled	Barriers cover at least half of China's 2023 exports; the relative share index is 85 or below, meaning China's position is at least 15 percent weaker than in 2023 against comparison markets; and China's own share of the market's imports has fallen at least 5 percent since 2023.	Mexico steel: 66 percent covered; China's share down from 10 to 7 percent, a relative share index of 66.
Closing	Barriers are going up, and the relative share index is 95 or below, meaning China's position is at least 5 percent weaker than in 2023 against comparison markets, or its goods are landing at least 10 percent higher in price than elsewhere while the index is 100 or below.	Brazil steel: 76 percent covered, up 14 points in a year; China's share up from 43 to 46 percent, but by less than elsewhere, a relative share index of 94.
Contested	Barriers are going up, or open investigations cover at least 20 percent, but China is not yet losing ground.	Mexico aluminum: 94 percent covered, China's share up from 25 to 29 percent.
Open	None of the above.	Malaysia EVs and batteries: no new barrier, China's share up from 44 to 83 percent.
Thin data	Too little trade data to judge outcomes. Not evidence of an open door.	Argentina solar.

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The rules are deliberately demanding. A walled reading requires China to lose ground in absolute terms, not merely to grow more slowly than elsewhere, so that stockpiling ahead of a tariff or a general slump in Chinese exports does not register as a wall. A market reads closing only when barriers and outcomes move together.

Using the Tool

The Sentry opens on an overview, followed by a card for each market and a drill-down for the selected market and sector. Each part answers one of four distinct questions.

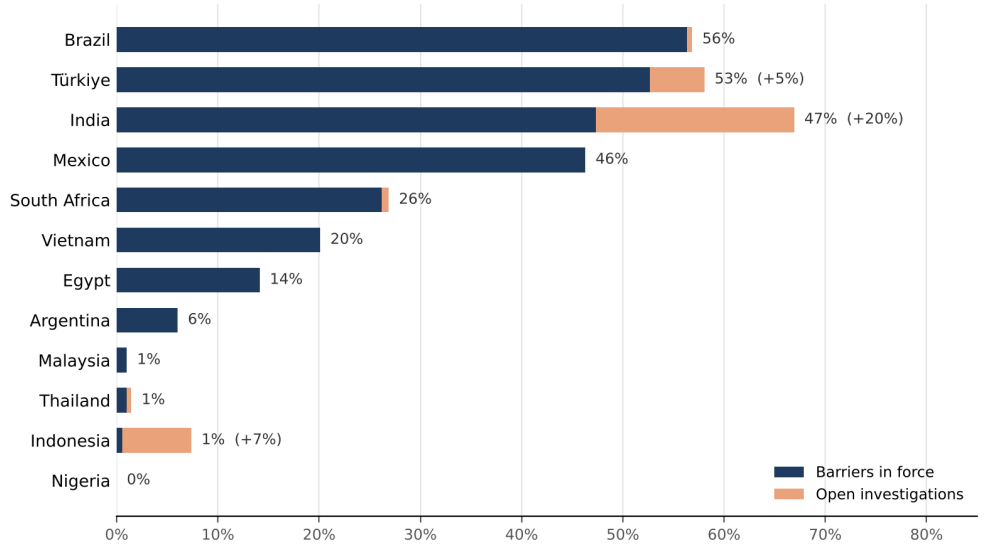


The overview: the map shows each market's most advanced status; the ranking shows the relative share index (below 100, China's position has weakened since 2023 against comparison markets) and, as dots, the share of its trade behind a barrier.

- **Where is China losing ground?** The map and the ranking beside it. The sector buttons above the ranking switch both to a single sector. Hovering over a market shows its status in each sector; clicking opens the drill-down.
- **How does each market look across sectors?** The market cards below the overview give each market's status in all five sectors at a glance, with markets ordered by how much ground China has lost.
- **What is driving the reading?** The drill-down opens with a short plain-language summary, followed by the rules that were met and not met, four headline figures, and four charts: barrier coverage over time, China's import share against comparison markets, the relative share index, and the price wedge.
- **Which measures are behind it?** The measures table at the foot of the drill-down lists every measure on the sector's product lines, with its dates, instrument, number of lines covered and whether it keeps Chinese goods out or pulls investment in. Each title links to the original Global Trade Alert record.

What the Data Show

Barrier coverage varies widely across the twelve markets. Brazil, Türkiye, India and Mexico have each put barriers on close to half or more of China's 2023 trade with them. Malaysia, Thailand, Indonesia and Nigeria have put almost none in place.



Share of China's 2023 exports to each market behind a barrier erected since 2022, with open investigations shown separately. All five sectors combined.

India

India is the market in which barriers are having the greatest impact. Steel reads walled: barriers cover 54 percent of China's 2023 exports, China's share of India's steel imports has fallen from 16 to 14 percent, a decline that, set against comparison markets where China's share edged up, leaves its position roughly a fifth weaker than in 2023 (a relative share index of 81). Aluminum and EVs and batteries read closing. In EVs and batteries, China's share has risen from 79 to 88 percent, but by less than in comparison markets. India is also where pressure is building fastest. Open investigations cover a further 29 percent of China's steel trade, including anti-dumping cases on hot-rolled flat products and grain-oriented electrical steel opened in June 2026, and more than thirty chemical cases are recorded as open, many of them on pharmaceutical intermediates such as penicillin G, 6-aminopenicillanic acid and amoxycillin.

Latin America

Brazil has the highest barrier coverage of any market, at 56 percent, but the results are mixed. Steel and solar read closing; in EVs and batteries, where Brazil's tariff ladder is designed to draw Chinese automakers into local assembly, China's share has risen from 54 to 81 percent and its goods are landing 24 percent cheaper than elsewhere. Mexico has the single clearest wall in the data, in steel, where China's share of Mexico's steel imports has fallen from 10 to 7 percent, leaving its position about a third weaker than in 2023 against comparison markets (a relative share index of 66). Its aluminum barriers have so far had no visible effect, and the effect of its January 2026 tariff increases on EVs will only show up in coming refreshes. Argentina has put few barriers in place, and China is gaining ground there in steel, aluminum, and EVs and batteries.

Southeast Asia

Indonesia, Thailand and Malaysia have put almost no barriers on China's trade in these sectors, and in most of them China is gaining ground fast. China's share of Malaysia's EV and battery imports has risen from 44 to 83 percent, and of Indonesia's from 38 to 76 percent. Thailand stands apart: China's position has weakened against comparison markets in solar, EVs and batteries, aluminum and steel, and in the first three its share has fallen outright, but without any barrier to explain it. Vietnam reads closing in steel, where barriers now cover 60 percent of China's trade and its exports have fallen from $6.5 billion in 2023 to $6.0 billion in 2025.

Africa and the Middle East

South Africa reads contested in steel and solar, with barriers covering 60 percent and 99 percent of China's trade respectively, but China's share has held up or risen in both. New anti-dumping and safeguard cases on flat-rolled steel, opened through the Southern African Customs Union in July 2026, may change that. Egypt has put barriers on 43 percent of China's steel trade, and while China's share of Egypt's steel imports has risen from 19 to 25 percent, it has risen by

considerably less than elsewhere, leaving China's position about a quarter weaker than in 2023 against comparison markets (a relative share index of 76). The reading nonetheless remains open, because those barriers went up more than a year ago and cover less than half of China's trade. In Egyptian chemicals, China's share has likewise risen by less than in comparison markets, in this case with no barrier in place at all. Nigeria has put no barriers on China's trade in these sectors, and China's share there has broadly held.

Türkiye

Türkiye reads closing in steel and EVs and batteries. Barrier coverage in EVs and batteries rose by 63 points in a single year, to 98 percent, and while China's share of Türkiye's imports in these products has held at around 22 percent, it has continued to rise elsewhere, leaving China's position some 12 percent weaker than in 2023 against comparison markets (a relative share index of 88). In solar, by contrast, barriers cover 97 percent of China's trade, yet China's share has risen from 80 to 89 percent, with its goods landing 29 percent cheaper than elsewhere. Türkiye's trade data currently run to December 2025, so the most recent measures are not yet reflected.

How robust are these results?

The comparison group includes Mexico and Canada, both of which have raised barriers of their own against Chinese goods. Removing either one alone changes at most two of the sixty readings. Removing both moves four pairs from closing to contested: India in EVs and batteries and in aluminum, and Brazil in steel and solar. Those four readings should therefore be treated as less firm than the others.

What to Watch

The table below sets out the cases most likely to move readings in coming editions. Investigation deadlines are the statutory maximum unless stated otherwise; authorities often conclude earlier.

Measure	Position now	Next date	Who must act
India: anti-dumping investigation on hot-rolled flat steel from China, Japan and Russia	Opened June 25, 2026; covers 34 product lines	Final findings due within a year of initiation, extendable by six months	Directorate General of Trade Remedies; Ministry of Finance
India: anti-dumping investigations on pharmaceutical intermediates (penicillin G, 6-APA, amoxycillin, clavulanic acid)	Opened September 2026	Final findings due by around September 2027	Directorate General of Trade Remedies; Ministry of Finance
Brazil: anti-dumping investigation on hot-rolled flat steel from China	Opened June 3, 2025	Statutory maximum of 18 months, around December 2026	Gecex (Executive Management Committee)
SACU: safeguard and anti-dumping investigations on flat-rolled steel	Opened July 10, 2026	Preliminary findings; no published date	International Trade Administration Commission
Indonesia: anti-dumping investigation on galvanized steel sheet from China	Opened September 15, 2026	Within 12 months, extendable to 18	Indonesian Anti-Dumping Committee (KADI); Ministry of Finance
Mexico: tariff increases of up to 50 percent on 1,463 lines from countries without a trade agreement	In force since January 1, 2026	Mexican trade data for June 2026 onward, in coming refreshes	n/a
EU: anti-dumping investigation on PVC from China, Taiwan, Mexico and South Korea	Opened September 29, 2026	Provisional duties, if any, within eight months, around May 2027	European Commission

What the Data Cannot Show

- **Informal barriers.** Customs delays, port inspections and informal guidance to importers are not recorded in Global Trade Alert and can matter as much as formal measures. A market with few recorded measures is not necessarily open.
- **Reporting lags.** Most markets' trade data run to May 2026, but Türkiye and Nigeria currently run only to December 2025, and Vietnam is read from annual data. Recent measures therefore show up in coverage before they can show up in outcomes.
- **Product mix.** Six-digit product lines group together goods of different grades and prices. A shift toward higher-value products can look like a price increase, which is why the price wedge is trimmed and capped.
- **Transshipment and relocation.** Chinese goods routed through a third country, or made by Chinese-owned plants abroad, do not appear as Chinese imports. Some of what reads as lost ground may simply have moved.

In Conclusion

The first data suggest that the Global South is not closing to Chinese exports, at least not yet. Barriers are going up, and in a handful of markets with large domestic industries to protect, above all in steel, they are holding. Elsewhere, China's share has kept rising despite the barriers, or fallen for reasons that have little to do with trade policy.

That pattern matters for how the next few years are likely to unfold. If the walls remain confined to a few large markets defending specific industries, China's exporters will have ample room to redirect, and the overall effect will be modest. If they spread, and particularly if the European Union's moves against Chinese chemicals push more product into markets that have so far stayed open, the Global South could become considerably less accommodating than it is today.

The Sentry is updated monthly as new measures are recorded and new trade data are published. For a firm or an investor, the practical questions are which markets it depends on, whether barriers there are holding, and where open investigations suggest that the terms of entry may soon change.

Sources and Register

Statements in this explainer rest on one of three registers. **Documented primary source:** official measures as recorded by Global Trade Alert and trade statistics published by UN Comtrade. **Attributed reporting:** named outlets and research providers, identified as such in the text. **Assessment:** the author's judgment, labeled where it appears.

Data. Global Trade Alert, global intervention database (globaltradealert.org), measures recorded to October 31, 2026, used under CC BY-NC 4.0; individual records are linked from the tool. UN Comtrade Database (comtradeplus.un.org), United Nations Statistics Division, monthly imports at the HS six-digit level and China's annual exports to Vietnam. Market Access X calculations.

Attributed reporting and research. James Crabtree, "The Coming Clash Between China and the Global South," *Foreign Policy*; KfW Development Research, "The impact of Chinese export surpluses on developing and emerging economies" (July 15, 2026); Board of Governors of the Federal Reserve System, FEDS Notes, "China Shock 2.0: How China's Ongoing Export Surge Differs from the Early 2000s" (May 29, 2026); White & Case on Mexico's January 2026 tariff increases; Hydrocarbon Processing and INEOS on the European Commission's PVC investigation (September 2026).

Further reading from Market Access X. *China's Place in the Global Life Sciences Value Chain* (October 2026); *The Terms of Entry*. All are available at marketaccess-x.com.

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